DRAFT for discussion. These letters were drafted by a community member for the Princeton Board of Education to consider. They have not been adopted, approved or sent by the Board and do not represent its position. Facts as of October 29, 2026.

Draft letters on the South Brunswick data center air permit

Letter 1: Board of Education to NJDEP

Send by November 9, 2026 through the online form at https://dep.nj.gov/boss/permit-comment-form/, or by mail.

[Date]

Nibras Mir
New Jersey Department of Environmental Protection
Bureau of Stationary Sources
401 E. State Street, 2nd Floor, PO Box 420, Mail Code 401-02
Trenton, NJ 08625-0420

Re: Draft Permit Comments for PN-DC1, PI 19525 PCP250001

Dear Nibras Mir:

The Princeton Board of Education submits these comments on the draft preconstruction permit for twelve diesel emergency generators at 4405 Route 1, South Brunswick. Our Littlebrook and Riverside Elementary Schools serve about 690 students, roughly 1.3 to 2 miles from the site, depending on where the generators sit on the 143-acre parcel. Closer still, within about a mile, are CIEL Senior Living, Spring Hills Princeton assisted living, Knowledge Beginnings child care, The Harmony School, and homes in South Brunswick, Kingston and Plainsboro. We ask the Department not to issue the permit until it has shown that children and residents are protected under every operating condition the permit allows.

1. The emission limits are calculated from testing hours only. The yearly limits equal exactly 12 engines × 28 hours of testing at the permitted hourly rates (for example, 75.28 lb/hr NOx × 336 hours = 12.65 tons). The permit lists each engine's yearly hours as 0 to 28. Yet Condition 18 also allows operation during power outages with no limit, for up to 30 days a year during construction, repair or maintenance at the facility, and during any PJM voltage reduction. The permit does not say whether these hours count toward the yearly limits, and the limits leave no room for them. At their permitted rates, all 12 engines together may emit about 900 lb of NOx per hour. About 55 hours of full operation would emit more than New Jersey's 25-ton-per-year major-source threshold.

2. The exhaust design keeps emissions low and close. The permit lists 33-foot stacks that discharge horizontally, 75 to 195 feet from the property line. Horizontal discharge removes the plume's

upward momentum. A 341,000-square-foot building beside the stacks may also pull exhaust down to the ground.

3. All 12 engines may run at once, at any hour. The permit limits testing to one engine at a time between 8 a.m. and 8 p.m., with up to six at once only between noon and 4 p.m. These limits suggest that running more engines at once was a concern. Yet during an outage or grid emergency, all 12 may run together, including during school hours and on high-ozone days.

4. There is no emissions monitoring. Every emission limit lists "None" for monitoring. Only hour meters, logs and fuel delivery records are required, kept on site and provided only on request.

5. The health risk assessment is not public. The notice states that health risk is "negligible" under Technical Manual 1003. The public cannot evaluate that finding without the assessment itself.

6. Other agencies treat these risks more conservatively. The World Health Organization's cancer agency classifies diesel engine exhaust as carcinogenic to humans. In February 2026, Delaware's DNREC denied a proposed data center near Delaware City over its diesel generators, evaluating them at 500 hours a year, the worst-case default in EPA guidance. Washington's Department of Ecology prepared a health impact assessment for a data center in Quincy, which found data centers responsible for 30 to 75% of cancer risk from major air sources there.

We request that the Department:

1. Release the health risk assessment, modeling protocol, model files and plot plan, disclose where the generators sit on the parcel, and extend the comment period so the public can review them.
2. Report modeled concentrations at Littlebrook and Riverside Elementary Schools, and at the nearest homes, CIEL Senior Living, Spring Hills Princeton, Knowledge Beginnings and The Harmony School. Include diesel particulate matter, 1-hour NO_2, formaldehyde and other air toxics, with early-life exposure adjustments for children.
3. Model all 12 engines running together at full load during school hours, for at least the 30-day maintenance allowance, a multi-day outage, and the 500-hour-per-year worst case in EPA guidance. Prepare a health impact assessment like Washington State's.
4. State whether emergency and maintenance operation counts toward the yearly limits. If not, count it toward the limits and the facility's source classification, or justify in writing why not.
5. Prohibit operation during PJM voltage reductions unless the facility has actually lost grid power.
6. Require Tier 4 engines or diesel particulate filters, taller vertical stacks, and fence-line monitoring with public reporting.
7. Require the operator to report every hour of generator operation, with its cause, to the Department and the public within 30 days.
8. Prohibit testing during school hours on school days.

Thank you for your consideration. Please send notice of the final decision and the Response to Comments to [contact name, address and email].

Sincerely,

[Name]
President, Princeton Board of Education

cc: Sen. Andrew Zwicker; Asm. Roy Freiman; Asm. Mitchelle Drulis; Mayor Mark Freda and Princeton Council; [Superintendent]

Letter 2: Board of Education to Bloomberg

[Date]

[Name, title]
Bloomberg L.P.
100 Business Park Drive
Skillman, NJ [ZIP to confirm]

cc: Kevin Groen, Director of Construction/Operations, Sentinel Data Centers, 505 Fifth Avenue, 27th Floor, New York, NY 10017

Re: Backup generators at the data center at 4405 Route 1, South Brunswick

Dear [Name]:

The Princeton Board of Education writes about the data center under construction at 4405 Route 1, which state records link to Bloomberg. Bloomberg is a valued neighbor, employing about 1,500 people at its Princeton campus. We ask Bloomberg to commit to protections that go beyond the minimum the draft state air permit requires.

The draft permit (NJDEP PCP250001) covers twelve 3,620 kW Tier 2 diesel generators with no add-on emission controls. Their 33-foot stacks discharge sideways, 75 to 195 feet from the property line. The permit limits testing to 28 hours per engine each year. It places no hour limit on operation during outages or PJM voltage reductions, and it allows up to 30 days a year during on-site construction, repair or maintenance. It requires no emissions monitoring. Our Littlebrook and Riverside Elementary Schools are roughly 1.3 to 2 miles from the site. Senior housing, an assisted-living residence, a child care center, a school and homes lie within about a mile.

Bloomberg has said the facility is not an AI or hyperscale data center and that its generators are all emergency backup generators. We welcome that, and ask Bloomberg to put it in writing with these commitments:

1. Fit the generators with diesel particulate filters and NOx controls, or use Tier 4 engines. In Virginia, more than half of the data center generator capacity permitted in 2025 was Tier 4.
2. Use battery storage to cover short outages so the generators start only for extended ones.
3. Run the generators only when the facility has lost grid power. Do not run them during PJM voltage reductions or demand-response events while grid power is available.
4. Schedule routine testing outside school hours on school days.
5. Publish a quarterly log of every hour of generator operation and its cause.
6. Fund air-quality monitoring at the property line and at our schools, with public results.
7. Confirm the total number of generators planned for the site. Princeton officials have cited 20 generators, while the draft permit covers 12.

These steps would set a high standard for data centers in New Jersey and give our families confidence that their children are protected. We would welcome a meeting with Bloomberg and Sentinel representatives to discuss them. Please contact [name, phone, email].

Sincerely,

[Name]
President, Princeton Board of Education

Letter 3: Board of Education to District 16 legislators

[Date]

Senator Andrew Zwicker
Assemblyman Roy Freiman
Assemblywoman Mitchelle Drulis
[District office address, to confirm]

Re: NJDEP draft permit PCP250001 and S4659/A5663

Dear Senator Zwicker, Assemblyman Freiman and Assemblywoman Drulis:

Thank you for requesting the extension of the comment period on the draft air permit for the data center at 4405 Route 1, South Brunswick. The Princeton Board of Education is submitting comments, attached. We ask for your help on two fronts.

This permit. The permit's yearly emission limits are calculated from only 28 hours a year of testing per generator. DEP has not said what operation its "negligible" health risk finding assumed. The permit also allows all 12 diesel generators to run with no hour limit during outages and PJM voltage reductions, and for up to 30 days a year during on-site repair or maintenance. The permit does not say whether those hours count toward the limits. The stacks are 33 feet tall, discharge sideways, and sit 75 to 195 feet from the property line, and no emissions monitoring is required. DEP has not released the health risk assessment. We ask you to urge DEP to:

1. Release the risk assessment and modeling, and extend the comment period again so the public can review them.
2. Model the permit's emergency and maintenance scenarios, with results at our schools and the nearest homes.
3. Add enforceable conditions: emergency hours counted toward the limits, cleaner engines or filters, monitoring and public reporting.

Statewide policy. Senator Zwicker, thank you for sponsoring S4659. We support it, its Assembly companion A5663, and the DEP study they require. Assemblyman Freiman and Assemblywoman Drulis, we ask you to sign on as co-sponsors of A5663. We also ask that the bills, or a companion measure:

1. Direct DEP to study how emergency generators at data centers are permitted, how often they run, and their cumulative impact near schools. In Northern Virginia, some data centers already emit 30% or more of their permitted amounts. During Winter Storm Fern in January 2026, the U.S. Department of Energy let the grid operator ask data centers to run their generators.
2. Require that all permitted generator operation, not only testing, count toward a facility's emissions and source classification. Delaware's DNREC evaluated a 2026 data center proposal at 500 hours a year, the worst-case default in EPA guidance.

3. Set standards for stack design, noise, monitoring and public reporting, with specific protections near schools.

The exemption in S4659/A5663 means it will not cover this facility. That makes it all the more important that DEP's decision on this permit sets a protective precedent.

We would welcome a meeting with you or your staff. Please contact [name, phone, email].

Sincerely,

[Name]
President, Princeton Board of Education

Enclosure: Board of Education comments to NJDEP

Letter 4: Board of Education to Princeton Mayor and Council

[Date]

Mayor Mark Freda and Members of Princeton Council
400 Witherspoon Street
Princeton, NJ 08540

Re: Coordinated response to NJDEP draft permit PCP250001

Dear Mayor Freda and Members of Council:

The Princeton Board of Education thanks you for your October 1 statement urging NJDEP to deny the air permit for the data center at 4405 Route 1 in its present form. We share your concern for our schools and are submitting our own comments, attached. We ask the municipality to take three further steps before the November 9 deadline.

1. **File detailed technical comments.** The draft permit's emission limits are calculated from testing hours only. It sets no hour limit on operation during outages and PJM voltage reductions, and up to 30 days a year during on-site maintenance. Its stacks are short and horizontal, close to the property line, and it requires no monitoring. Specific comments on these conditions will carry more weight than a request to deny.
2. **Retain an independent air-quality consultant.** A consultant can review DEP's risk assessment and modeling once released. If they are not released, a consultant can model the permit's emergency scenarios and estimate concentrations at our schools.
3. **Request the records.** Ask DEP, through an OPRA request if needed, for the health risk assessment, modeling protocol, model files and plot plan for PI 19525 / PCP250001.

We would also welcome the municipality's help with longer-term steps. These include baseline air-quality and noise measurements near our schools before the facility operates, and coordination with South Brunswick and Middlesex County on noise enforcement.

We would be glad to work with you. Please contact [name, phone, email].

Sincerely,

[Name]
President, Princeton Board of Education

Enclosure: Board of Education comments to NJDEP

Letter 5: Board of Education to Princeton University

Lower priority than Letter 1. Consider having the Superintendent make first contact.

[Date]

[Name, title, to confirm]
Office of Community and Regional Affairs [office name to confirm]
Princeton University
Princeton, NJ 08544

cc: Office of the President

Re: Data center at 4405 Route 1, South Brunswick

Dear [Name]:

The Princeton Board of Education writes about the data center under construction on part of the former Princeton Nurseries land, which the University sold to WRV Nurseries South Brunswick in 2024. NJDEP is reviewing a draft air permit (PCP250001) for twelve diesel backup generators there. Comments are due November 9. Our Littlebrook and Riverside Elementary Schools are roughly 1.3 to 2 miles away, and University research facilities are reported to be within about a mile.

The draft permit's emission limits are calculated from testing hours only. It sets no hour limit on operation during power outages or grid emergencies, the stacks are short and discharge sideways, and no emissions monitoring is required. DEP has not released its health risk assessment.

We ask for the University's help in four ways:

1. **Land-use terms.** Please tell us whether the University retained any covenants, deed restrictions or agreements in the 2024 sale that bear on how the land may be used or on emissions from it.
2. **Expert review.** Would University faculty in air quality, public health or energy be willing to review DEP's risk assessment and modeling once released, or advise on the scenarios DEP should evaluate?
3. **Air monitoring.** Would the University consider supporting baseline and ongoing air-quality monitoring near the site and our schools, for example as a research or teaching project?
4. **A comment to DEP.** As a neighboring landowner with facilities and employees nearby, the University may wish to submit its own comment by November 9.

We value our long partnership with the University and would welcome a conversation. Please contact [name, phone, email].

Sincerely,

[Name]
President, Princeton Board of Education

Before sending: checklist and sources

The letters need the Board's approval, filled placeholders, and a check of the facts below.

Board vote or authorization, and the signer's name (Dafna Kendal was president as of January 2025; 2026 officers not confirmed)
Confirm with the district: Littlebrook and Riverside are the two schools meant; about 357 and 330 students (district profiles, year not stated); 1.3 to 2.1 miles depending on where the generators sit on the parcel (Block 99, Lot 14.04, 142.878 acres). Ask South Brunswick for the approved site plan, or DEP for the plot plan, to pin this down
Verify the nearby facilities (CIEL Senior Living, Spring Hills Princeton, Knowledge Beginnings, The Harmony School) on a current map; they come from OpenStreetMap
Contact person for replies (name, phone, email)
Bloomberg recipient, and the ZIP for 100 Business Park Drive, Skillman (listings show both 08540 and 08558); the Bloomberg link comes from NJDEP site records and its own statements to NJ.com
District 16 office address (listings show Hillsborough for Zwicker and Flemington for Drulis); 400 Witherspoon Street is confirmed. Check njleg.gov for current S4659/A5663 co-sponsors before sending Letter 3; as introduced, Zwicker is a prime sponsor of S4659 and neither Freiman nor Drulis is on A5663
Re-check permit figures against DEP's posted draft. They were taken from a copy posted by Stop NJ Data Centers whose identifiers and totals match DEP's notice.
Confirm the 20-generator figure before citing it beyond Letter 2. The permit does not say whether emergency hours count toward the yearly limits; the letters ask DEP to say, rather than asserting it.
Optional: copy the Superintendent, the Princeton Health Department, and Middlesex County health officials on noise

Sources

- NJDEP draft permit PCP250001 (copy)
- NJDEP amended public notice (copy)
- S4659 text
- A5663 text
- Bloomberg linked to data center (NJ.com via Yahoo)
- Central Jersey Media: South Brunswick data center rises amid growing opposition
- Town Topics: Princeton to NJDEP: Deny Data Center Permit
- Better Data Center Project: Diesel Generators at Data Centers (Mar 2026)
- VCU: Northern Virginia data center air pollution rivals power plant emissions (Feb 2026)
- Spotlight Delaware: Delaware City data center faces setback after environmental denial
- Han et al., The Unpaid Toll: Quantifying the Public Health Impact of AI
- NJ parcel data (NJGIN composite)
- OpenStreetMap